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Enhancing B2B sales through digital transformation: Insights into effective sales enablement

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ABSTRACT

Business-to-business (B2B) firms increasingly face the challenge of enabling their sales force to interact with informed customers during the sales process. Consequently, B2B firms have been investing in sales enablement initiatives to help their salespeople have value-adding dialogue with their customers. Due to the evolving influence of digital technologies on buyer behaviors, B2B sales organizations are responding by deploying digital technologies as part of their sales enablement initiatives. Yet, practitioners and sales research lack insights on how digital technologies actually enable the sales force to deal with the challenges of the sales process. Basing ourselves on a qualitative field-study involving interviews with 26 B2B sales executives, we studied how sales organizations deployed digital technologies to help their salespeople along the sales process. Our empirical findings offer two contributions to extant sales enablement literature. First, our study gives structured and nuanced insights on how digital technologies are deployed as part of sales enablement initiatives along the entire sales process by a) facilitating customer facing sales interactions, b) facilitating internal work efficiencies, and c) salesperson capability enhancement. Second the findings from our study helped us propose a digital sales enablement framework that showcases the impact of digital sales enablement on performance outcomes. Our framework also identified two sets of contextual factors that could affect the digital sales enablement-performance outcomes relationship.

1. Introduction

The business-to-business (B2B) sales process has undergone significant changes over the past two decades. Salespeople currently have to be knowledge brokers (Verbeke et al., 2011), provide extra value-added services (Rapp et al., 2017), and deal with selling complex solutions requiring them to work with diverse stakeholders (Hartmann et al., 2018). Recently, various digital technologies have also notably changed the nature of sales processes as increasingly informed, demanding, professional customers expect digitally rooted sales interactions (Bowen et al., 2022; Rangarajan et al., 2021). At the same time sales organizations are investing in digital sales tools including artificial intelligence for leveraging the opportunities in new technologies for digitally transforming the sales (Guenzi & Habel, 2020; McClure et al., 2024; Syam & Sharma, 2018).

The changes mentioned have added multiple layers of complexity to the sales process, prompting researchers to advocate for an adaptive, flexible approach for sales organizations to help their salespeople navigate these challenges (Flaherty & Schroeder, 2022). From a B2B sales force standpoint, these changes mean increased pressure on salespeople to not only untangle their customers' complex needs but also to internally access diverse organizational resources critical for navigating the sales process efficiently with the goal of adding value to customer interactions (Terho et al., 2017). To help salespeople engage in value-adding sales dialogue with customers, B2B firms are investing in cross-functional "sales enablement" initiatives (see Peterson et al., 2021). Peterson et al. (2021) recently conceptualized sales enablement as an organization wide, cross-functional initiative consisting of insight triangulation, enablement infrastructure, and sales support development for helping salespeople succeed. This view builds on the dynamic

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capability view, which highlights that firm's ability to engage in market-based learning and use the resulting insight to reconfigure the firm's resources and enhance its capabilities to match market environment explains business performance variance between firms over time (see Morgan, 2012; Teece et al., 1997). Here, the objective of sales enablement is to "better prepare the selling organization to serve the buyer's needs, with more efficient and effective coordination of various enablement services such as training services, customer-facing and internal enablement content services, sales coaching services, and sales tools" (Peterson & Dover, 2021, p. 155).

Although the topic's practical relevance is widely agreed upon, the research on sales enablement is still embryonic. Extant sales enablement literature highlights two knowledge gaps. First, sales enablement studies to date have focused on defining and understanding what sales enablement is through fairly abstract conceptual studies rooted in organizational dynamic capabilities literature and have paid less attention to its successful implementation at the salesperson level (Peterson & Dover, 2020; Peterson & Dover, 2021; Rangarajan et al., 2020; Rapp & Beeler, 2021), This is an issue since recent research points out that firms face notable challenges in deploying their multi-functional sales enablement initiatives into practice (Lauzi et al., 2023). Arguably, research lacks insights of the holistic deployment of sales enablement into frontline practice along the entire sales process from pre-sales to post-sales. Second, the extant literature has indicated that sales enablement deployments are increasingly being supported by advanced digital technologies (see Friend et al., 2024). Some studies have even provided empirical evidence about the positive impact of technologies on sales enablement effectiveness (Westbrook & Peterson, 2020). Yet, extant sales enablement research lacks a systematic and structured view on the diverse functions that digital technologies play in sales enablement deployment. This notion is in keeping with calls by researchers who argue for a more holistic approach towards understanding how digital technologies are shaping the sales function (Agnihotri et al., 2023; McClure et al., 2024).

Against this background, the purpose of this research is twofold. First, the study aims to understand digital technology facilitated sales enablement initiatives and activities needed to translate the sales enablement concept into concrete salesforce practice at sales process level. Second the study will examine the potential performance outcomes of digital sales enablement along the sales process as well as on the contextual factors affecting the performance relationship. To do this, we employ an empirical, qualitative research design involving 26 sales executives from 24 firms and use an inductive approach to advance the inquiry into the study topic.

The findings show how firms can leverage technologies in sales enablement deployment though three key functions and related activities along the entire sales process: by facilitating salespeople's customer facing sales interactions, by facilitating salespeople's internal work efficiency, and by building the sales team's capabilities. A conceptual framework of digital sales enablement further outlines its likely relationship to sales performance outcomes as well as provides rich insights into how organizational and infrastructural factors are likely to impact its performance outcomes. Therefore, this study makes a conceptual "delineating contribution" (see MacInnis, 2011) by depicting what digital sales enablement means and understanding its close nomological network. Overall, the framework helps understanding how the Peterson and Dover (2020) strategic sales enablement infrastructure, consisting of the sales conduit and enablement infrastructure, can translate into concrete sales process support at salesforce level.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. The next section provides the conceptual basis of the study by discussing the extant research on sales enablement. We then outline the qualitative research methodology used in our study. We go on to report the empirical results in two parts. First, we present the results on the three key functions of digital sales enablement. Second, we provide a framework of digital sales enablement summarizing its key functions along sales process. Finally, we outline the theoretical and managerial implications of this research and conclude with the limitations and future research discussion.

2. Deploying dynamic sales enablement capability into sales practice

Sales enablement was originally a practitioner concept rooted in cross-functional, organization-wide support for sales activities aimed at more effective, customer-centric selling (Santucci, 2010). On the macro level, sales enablement initiatives are customer-focused with an underlying goal of helping salespeople targeting right customers and selling more effectively. Studies on sales enablement have broadly focused on sales strategy, sales technologies, and developing salespeople as human resources (Rapp & Beeler, 2021). Research has recently noted this concept's importance, but to our knowledge, only six empirical and three conceptual studies have focused on understanding what the sales enablement concept entails. Table 1 summarizes these studies on sales enablement, outlining their purpose, methods and data, and key findings.

The research on sales enablement has conceptualized it as a dynamic capability that "aligns various firm resources to benefit the customer journey and selling productivity" (Peterson et al., 2021, p. 543). From the sales organization's perspective, the concept represents a firm-wide strategic initiative that incorporates three elements, namely people, process, and performance, to deliver value to seller firms and customers alike (Rangarajan et al., 2020). Overall, the research emphasizes that sales enablement should be considered as a set of cross-functional initiatives within an organization aimed at improving the sales force's effectiveness and efficiency (Lauzi et al., 2023). For instance, Peterson and Dover (2021) specified that the concept focuses on "cross-functional assimilation of content, processes, and technology that readies a firm to more productively assist the customer's journey." Peterson et al. (2021, p. 543) state-of-the-art research on sales enablement distinguishes three key components in sales enablement as a dynamic capability, namely insight triangulation, enablement infrastructure, and sales support development. They note that these components further drive the sales enablement process that includes sales support diagnostics, sales capital reconfiguration, enablement infrastructure rollout, enablement performance evaluation, and enablement calibration. Finally, other studies have further indicated that although salespeople and account managers are the primary focus of sales enablement initiatives, sales enablement serves starkly different stakeholders, and the services offered, such as training, content, tools, processes, on-boarding, and coaching, also vary widely among organizations (see Keeling et al., 2020; Peterson & Dover, 2021).

This study builds on the Peterson et al. (2021) sales enablement conceptualization as the starting point for extending the current understanding how digital technologies can be used to deploy this strategic dynamic capability into practice at sales process level. Out of the three sales enablement components of insight triangulation, enablement infrastructure, and sales support development, the enablement infrastructure represents the key component from the deployment perspective. Specifically, the enablement infrastructure "serves as an integrative hub that brings together widely dispersed intra-firm resources, capabilities, activities, and ideas intended to help sales personnel" Peterson et al. (2021, p. 553), being the component that ultimately links the strategic dynamic capability components to frontline employees with concrete actions. Interestingly, the enablement infrastructure consists of two sub-components, namely technical structure and sales conduit (Peterson et al., 2021). The technical structure refers to constantly evolving set of technology platforms and aligned processes that enable the transfer of the diverse organizational enablement resources to support sales. In turn, sales conduit channels sales force needs to a variety of intrafirm entities, coordinates sales-support inputs to help salespeople achieve their objectives, and redirects those inputs back to sellers, that

Table 1
Summary of studies on sales enablement.

Article	Purpose	Methods	Key findings	Study's contribution
Plangger et al. (2020)	To conceptualize strategic sales enablement investments through the lens of human and technological enablers' knowledge transfer capabilities	Conceptual	Investments in strategic enablement in the form of human and technological enablers result in four types of learning environments: adaptive learning, complex learning, self-directed learning, and collaborative learning.	Identifies multiple themes for strategic enablement investments
Rangarajan et al. (2020)	To explore how the effects of sales enablement enhance the productivity of the sales force	Qualitative empirical with in-depth interviews	This study conceptualizes sales enablement as an organization-wide business strategy integrating people, process, and performance through effective leadership. It proposes the broad influence of digital technologies on sales enablement. A comprehensive list of 24 research questions is presented for future investigation.	Sales enablement is positioned as a strategic organizational initiative impacting sales performance, instead of viewing it as an operational practice.
Westbrook and Peterson (2020)	To investigate empirically the impact of sales enablement resources on salesperson's performance outcomes.	Empirical with a survey administered to 302 respondents	The study finds that sales enablement initiatives reduces salesperson's burnout and turnover while positively impacting sales performance.	Positions sales enablement as a job resource that can impact salesperson's performance, burnout, and turnover intention. Besides, the study developed a measurement mechanism for the multifaceted sales enablement concept.
Peterson and Dover (2020)	To introduce the concept of sales enablement and suggest overarching research areas.	Conceptual	The study identifies the appropriateness of dynamic capability theory in explaining sales enablement and provides a framework that positions sales enablement as the conduit between the customer's journey and the selling process.	Contextualized sales enablement in academic research. Conceptualizing three components of sales enablement (technology-content-people) provides a framework for future researchers.
Peterson and Dover (2021)	To study the global diffusion of sales enablement and measure the effect of dedicated resource variance on sales enablement accomplishments in different markets	Empirical with a survey administered to 561 respondents	The study explains the differences across markets in terms of sales enablement understanding and implementation. Across regions, firms' sales enablement initiatives vary according to who to serve and which services to offer as well as the productivity goals. These differences are critical to designing a global sales enablement initiative.	The study highlights the importance of regional differences in deciding whom to serve and which services to offer for effective implementation of sales enablement initiative.
Peterson et al. (2021)	To conceptualize sales enablement and provide an in-depth processual view of how firms develop this capability	Empirical, ethnography, netnography, and in-depth interviews	The study provides a framework for sales enablement by linking insight triangulation, enablement infrastructure, and sales support development. This study conceptualizes sales enablement as an integrative dynamic capability that binds disparate organizational processes such as organizational learning, change management, and technology adoption.	Explicates a process model of developing sales enablement as a dynamic capability.
Lauzi et al. (2023)	To provide a generalized understanding of sales enablement within a firm, that is, how sales enablement is understood and implemented	Empirical case study of a single company involving 25 in-depth interviews	Highlights varying perspectives on sales enablement within the organization. The study suggests that intra-firm coordination is an important driver of sales enablement, but the lack of consensus on how to measure its effectiveness is a clear barrier to effective implementation.	The study provides insight about sales enablement deployment and the factors that impact sales enablement initiatives.
Friend et al. (2024)	To provide an integrated and cohesive framework of sales enablement within a firm and develop a typology of sales enablement, keeping in mind the heterogeneity inherent in the construct.	Conceptual	The study identified three components of sales enablement strategy; people focusing on capability development, process component focusing on content management and internal interaction and systems component focusing on sales technology and its acceptance.	Positions sales enablement as a cohesive firm wise enablement strategy instead of collection of sales support function. The integrative typology synthesizes people, process, performance framework from extant SE literature with constructs in related knowledge areas (such as organizational learning, change management, technology adoption).
Peterson and Munoz (2024)	To provide an understanding of tasks, responsibilities, expectations, and qualifications of the senior sales enablement managers.	Secondary textual data comprising 131 job postings of director-level enablement roles	The main responsibility themes are sales catalyst, learning, marketing, and sales operations. The study brings out four areas of expectations: internal and external liaison, leadership, and systematic problem solver. The organizations also look for diverse experience, varied communication capabilities, distinct individual abilities, and collaborative skills.	The study logically develops a definition of the sales enablement role. This would allow researchers to conduct performance/effectiveness studies and measure the effect of sales enablement activities.

is, it deploys all various offered organizational enablement support into concrete actions at sales process level.

This study extends the knowledge in this area by studying the "digital sales enablement" functions and activities that translate the dynamic capability enablement infrastructure into concrete salesforce practice at sales process level with the help of digital technologies. This view is aligned with the broader dynamic capability research arguing that the "reconfiguration" of firm assets and routines (Teece, 2007) is the key aspect for making firms operational resources and capabilities to fit the environment (Pavlou & El Sawy, 2011). The study focuses on creating a framework that provides insights into the areas where firms can enable their salesforce at sales process level in dynamic conditions, ultimately helping firms to manage the transformation and change of frontline sales process in sales enablement (c.f. Girod & Whittington, 2017).

3. Methods

3.1. Research approach

Due to the nascent nature of the sales enablement research, we adopted a qualitative field study approach that is well suited for theory-building research (Peterson et al., 2021; Terho, Mero et al., 2022; Terho, Salonen, & Yrjänen, 2022). Given that the existing literature has not sufficiently theorized B2B sales enablement deployment (Rangarajan et al., 2020), we adopted an inductive research approach (Gioia et al., 2013). Next, we will discuss collection of the qualitative data, data analysis, and the trustworthiness of the research with reference to established guidelines.

3.2. Data collection

We collected data via semi-structured interviews with 26 senior executives working in sales, marketing, and sales enablement roles in the Information System (IS) industry. We chose the IS industry as the empirical setting for the study for two reasons. First, the IS firms can provide insights into complex sales processes since they mainly sell customized software solutions to their customers. The participating firms were characterized by long sales cycles and their sales process involves salespeople working with multiple people both from the customers' as well as their own organization. Second, IS firms are the forerunners in adopting and using digital technologies to deploy their sales enablement initiatives (see Terpoorten et al., 2024). Thus, the IS industry context provides an interesting context to study digital sales enablement in the context of complex sales process. The participant firms widely used digital technologies to help their sales teams in the sales process.

We developed an interview guide (Appendix A) that focused on how sales organizations used digital technologies to help their salespeople

Table 2
Sample characteristics.

Firm	No. employees	Key Offering	Interviewee	Interviewee's job title	Ind. experience	Int. length
Firm 1	40–100	B2B Sales support	R1	Head of Sales	22 years	90 min.
Firm 2	> 10,000	Business consulting and technology services	R2	Head of sales (Telecom, media and technology)	20 years	51 min.
			R4	Director – Consulting	22 years	63 min.
Firm 3	1001–5000	Business process management	R3	General Manager –Marketing	15 years	59 min.
Firm 4	> 10,000	IS solution comprising hardware, software, consulting, and IT services	R5	Client Partner	21 years	60 min.
Firm 5	1001–5000	Software products (cybersecurity)	R6	Marketing Lead	22 years	45 min.
Firm 6	1001–5000	Enterprise cloud solution	R7	Head of Sales (Cloud Solution)	25 years	64 min.
Firm 7	1001–5000	Business consulting and technology services	R8	Director- Client Services	24 years	53 min.
Firm 8	> 10,000	IS solution comprising hardware, software, consulting, and IT services	R9	Associate Partner- Cloud Business	19 years	51 min.
Firm 9	101–1000	Software products (CRM and marketing automation)	R10	Vice president – commercial operations	27 years	71 min.
Firm 10	> 10,000	Software products (ERP, Data management and CRM)	R11	Partner Success Executive	25 years	95 min.
			R19	Global Account Director	21 years	49 min.
Firm 11	1001–5000	Cloud computing service	R12	Cloud Sales Specialist	10 years	70 min.
Firm 12	5001–10,000	Software and communication services	R13	Associate Director – Sales Operations	25 years	58 min.
Firm 13	5001–10,000	Communication network infrastructure and services	R14	Director	33 years	35 min.
Firm 14	101–1000	Software Product (Enterprise digital adaption platform)	R15	Director – Sales	28 years	42 min.
Firm 15	40–100	Software Product (Customer experience management)	R16	Vice President – Business Management	15 years	63 min.
Firm 16	1001–5000	Cloud computing infrastructure	R17	Pre-sales lead	24 years	51 min.
Firm 17	> 10,000	Industrial technology	R18	Performance Marketing Manager	13 years	52 min.
Firm 18	101–1000	Software and digital services for manufacturing industry	R20	Global account Director	7 years	55 min.
Firm 19	101–1000	Software product (Contract lifecycle management)	R21	Pre-sales Manager	8 years	57 min.
Firm 20	101–1000	Software product (Customer service management)	R22	Head of Global Demand Generation	27 years	110 min.
Firm 21	1001–5000	Business consulting and technology services	R23	Partner and COO	25 years	45 min.
Firm 22	1001–5000	Digital payment solution for B2B industry	R24	Senior Vice President – Sales	17 years	40 min.
Firm 23	> 10,000	IS solution comprising hardware, software, consulting, and IT services	R25	Cloud Solution Manager	28 years	35 min.
Firm 24	40–100	Software product (website personalization solution)	R26	CEO	12 years	90 min.

across the sales process. To attain rich data, we asked open-ended questions, and the interviewees were free to express their views on any issues they felt were relevant to our research (Hesse-Biber & Leavy, 2010; Zeithaml et al., 2020). The data collection was conducted from late 2022 to January, 2023. We conducted 26 interviews with managers in sales, marketing and sales enablement roles at large, leading IS firms. We stopped qualitative data collection when we reached data saturation, that is, when no new theoretical themes were evident in the interviews. Table 2 summarizes the interviewees' characteristics.

The duration of each interview ranged from 35 min to 110 min, with an average duration of 60 min. The interviewees had diverse backgrounds and job titles such as head of marketing, sales director, account executive, business head, partner success executive, and director of demand generation. This variety allowed us to gather rich insights into digital sales enablement (Riege, 2003). Moreover, the interviewees' years of experience in the IS industry varied in the range of 7–33 years. Two of the authors also had prior working experience in the IS industry, which allowed us to steer the interviews to gain an understanding of the nuances and implicit issues in sales enablement (see Zeithaml et al., 2020).

3.3. Data analysis

Data analysis followed the multi-stage inductive approach Gioia et al. (2013) have espoused. First, two researchers independently conducted extensive open coding to generate a comprehensive initial understanding of the data, which allowed us to appreciate the data's heterogeneity. To name the codes, we used in-vivo coding; that is, we used the informant's language whenever possible and used simple descriptive phrases in other cases. Building on these rich open codes, we identified theoretically meaningful first-order concepts, following Gioia et al. (2013). This process was recursive; the codes were reviewed multiple times, overlapping codes were merged, and codes that represented minor issues not essential to our research were excluded from the analysis. We continued this analytic process until the resultant codes were deemed satisfactory and representative of the available data. Next, we performed axial coding, which focused on identifying the relationships between and among the first-order concepts. This allowed us to assemble them into second-order themes (see Gioia et al., 2013).

We then performed selective coding (Gioia et al., 2013) in which we further increased the level of abstraction by grouping the second-order themes into three so-called aggregate dimensions. The selective coding further focused on understanding patterns of digital sales enablement sub-activities at different sales process stages, identifying the potential outcomes of digital sales enablement, as well as the various contingency factors to ascertain the effectiveness of sales enablement deployment. Specifically, Tables 3–5 summarize the digital sales enablement functions, showing their first-order codes (components), the second-order themes (sub-activities), and the third-order aggregate dimensions (activities). To add transparency to the interpretation of the data, we use power quotes from the interviewees to further illustrate the results (Pratt, 2009).

Table 3
Digital sales enablement functions for facilitating customer-facing sales interactions.

3rd-order aggregate dimension	2nd-order themes, sub-activities	1st-order components	*Sales process mapped*
Facilitation of customer-facing sales interaction	Sales opportunity identification	Automated prospect and lead generation Lead enrichment with relevant information Integration of customers' procurement systems	*Lead & pre-approach*
	Sales lead engagement support	Support for managing social media presence and engaging audiences Tools for sharing personalized content sequences across relevant channels Digital lead nurturing support for strategic accounts Development of market insights for the lead process	*Lead & pre-approach*
	Sales interaction approach guidance	Buyer persona insights Support for consensus building among buying center members Customer interaction strategy support based on customer analytics	*Sales Negotiation*
	Value proposition communication	Support for interactive solution demonstrations Support for communicating the value of the proposed solution Global sales team support to augment local sales efforts	*Sales Negotiation*
	Customer value realization	Customer success management and value realization support Tools for communicating the realized value to the customer Customer problem and incident management system for sales Social listening to understand the brand's reputation User analytics-based updates of ideal customer profiles to boost future sales	*Value delivery & relationship management*

3.4. Research trustworthiness

We assessed the quality of the findings according to the established criteria for evaluating the trustworthiness of qualitative research, that is, its credibility, dependability, confirmability, transferability, and distinctiveness (Lincoln & Guba, 1985; Zeithaml et al., 2020).

To enhance the findings' credibility, we deployed multiple strategies. The most important was source triangulation (Patton, 2014), which we achieved by recruiting research participants with different professional roles (digital marketing, sales, pre-sales, client engagement, and customer success) and levels of expertise (ranging from 7 years to 27 years of relevant work experience) to ensure the authenticity and representativeness of the data (Zeithaml et al., 2020). During the interview process, we probed the topic of interest deeply and examined rival explanations (Yin, 2009). For example, we sought to find out whether a similar outcome would have been achieved without the use of digital technologies in a specific context. Regarding the dependability of our analysis, we utilized investigator triangulation (Flick, 2004; Patton, 2014) where two researchers did the initial coding, and the whole team discussed the interpretations.

We improved the study's confirmability by establishing a chain of evidence to ensure the reliability of the information (Yin, 2009). Each of the key findings was supported and illustrated by relevant quotations from our interview database. Additionally, in the last phase of our research, we used practitioners' language to present our findings to five managers working in the IS industry. The managers assessed the

Table 4
Digital sales enablement functions for facilitating internal work efficiency.

3rd-order aggregate dimensions	2nd-order themes	1st-order components	*Sales process mapped*
Facilitation of internal work efficiency	Optimize resources in lead nurturing	Automated scheduling of sales meetings Automating routine prospecting and lead management tasks Lead scoring and prioritization	*Lead & pre-approach*
	Design value proposition	Harvesting and reusing assets in proposal development Competitive benchmarking for sales proposals Solution configuration support for effective customization and sizing	*Sales Negotiation*
	Coordination and collaboration	Centralized content platform for easy access and sharing of content Content optimization for improved customer engagement Pipeline status visibility to enhance sales team collaboration Technology-enabled deal closing Effective deal handover from the sales team to the post-sales solution delivery team	*All three processes*
	Account growth and retention	Insights for account planning Customer analytics-driven cross-, up-, and re-selling initiatives Analytics-based customer retention and churn management support Analytics-driven sales growth forecasting Effective payment realization support for served customers	*Value delivery & relationship management*

Table 5
Digital sales enablement functions for facilitating capability enhancement.

3rd-order aggregate dimensions	2nd-order themes	1st-order components	*Sales process mapped*
Facilitating capacity enhancement	Effective on-boarding	On-boarding tools to shorten new salespeople's ramp-up time	*All three processes*
	Coaching and performance management	Proactive sales management coaching to boost salespeople's productivity Target setting and incentive disbursement support	
	Knowledge and skills acquisition	Customized, self-paced learning for salespeople Digital lead management skillsets Learning from lost leads Feedback-based optimization of lead nurturing approaches	

research conclusions, key themes, and propositions as being in sync with their professional experiences and the emerging industry practices.

We aimed to increase the findings' transferability by including different types of interviewees from diverse IS organizations (e.g., new vs. traditional, product vs. services, domestic market-focused vs. export-oriented). Since different types of IS and consulting organizations also implement sales enablement solutions for other traditional organizations, the practices IS organizations adopt are more likely to be diffused across other industries over time.

Finally, our study's distinctiveness lies in the fact that our findings synthesize two distinct research streams: sales enablement and digital technologies' effects on sales. Our study makes a unique contribution to the research by offering systematic, comprehensive insights into digital enablement deployment and the contingency factors that impact its performance.

4. Results

We report the empirical findings aligned with the twofold purpose of the study. First, we start by presenting the empirical findings on how B2B firms leverage digital technologies to deploy their cross-functional sales enablement initiatives. We find three key dimensions of digital sales enablement, namely 1) facilitation of customer facing sales interactions, 2) facilitation of internal work efficiency, and 3) capability enhancement. We discuss these functions and their more detailed sub-activities plus components in detail in sections 4.1–4.3. Section 4.4. provides a digital sales enablement framework that outlines how the three digital sales enablement functions manifest along the sales process as well as summarizes its likely outcomes and contingency factors that affect the performance relationship.

4.1. Sales enablement in facilitating customer-facing sales interactions

The facilitation of customer-facing sales interaction focuses on enhancing the quality of sales interactions with leads and customers by adding digital modes of interaction and better adaption of content messaging based on data-driven insights (see Guenzi & Habel, 2020). It comprises of five sub-activities and their detailed components as summarized in Table 3.

4.1.1. Sales opportunities identification

First, the analysis of the interview data suggested that organizations have systematically increased reliance on technology-enabled sales opportunity identification (see Terho, Salonen, & Yrjänen, 2022). This includes the lead acquisition for sales team, which is achieved through multiple digital marketing and online procurement channels and enriching them with rich and usable information. Digitally enabled lead generation has replaced traditional field sales-based lead acquisition in many places and has helped salespeople to better reach prospects while exerting less effort. Our data analysis identified three components of sales opportunity identification (see Table 3).

The interviewees mentioned that technologies allow them to capture prospects' intentions through monitoring of their digital activities, which results in *automated prospect and lead generation*. This allows salespeople access to a large number of leads without the requirement of their active involvement. Our data analysis results show that marketing plays a key role in many organizations in this domain by providing salespeople with qualified inbound leads. This trend is even more prevalent in organizations involved in selling standardized, productized IT solutions and products. The comment below discusses this in detail.

> A lot of organizations which previously were heavily dependent on outbound [leads] are now dependent on 100 % inbound leads, so that your prospects come to you rather than you go[ing] after them. For inbound leads, we get help from our marketing team; they deploy digital marketing techniques such as search campaigns, display

campaigns, re-marketing campaigns, search engine optimization, content marketing, [and] webinars.

(R22)

The data analysis further shows technologies' increasingly important role in *lead enrichment with relevant information*. Traditionally, for any lead, the seller's information acquisition is limited to collating important stakeholders' contact details and job titles. With social media-enabled tools and databases, however, sellers acquire additional information about the members of the buying unit. Such information comprises their education, career progress, and other demographic details. The information collected are refined continuously by tracking people's real-time online behavior and social media footprint (such as recent content consumed and website visited) (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). In addition to the demographic details, AI provides clues about customer's traits and preferences, customer's current interest and purchase journey stage, which the sellers can use to initiate discussions.

This component entails the progressive utilization of multiple types of data to continuously accumulate information about key individuals as illustrated in the following comment.

One of the most interesting pillars of sales digitalization is the enrichment pillar, right? I have already spoken about knowing who you are speaking to. The whole enrichment pillar is trying to give you more and more information, and this is beyond data points. I am not only talking about where he works [and] his phone number but also what he did on Facebook or LinkedIn in the last week. Can I convert [people's] social media activities into intent? Can I convert that into characters, right? This is enrichment.

(R22)

The interviewees also highlighted the ease of accessing customer-initiated opportunities by linking salespeople to customers through *integration of customers' procurement systems* with sellers' IT system. Digital access to various types of customer-initiated opportunities (RFI, RFP, reverse bidding, and other forms of proposal request) has eliminated the need for manual communication and physical travel as part of sales operations. Sellers' presence in customers' online procurement systems allows salespeople to access opportunities and tenders from any geographical location or department through a centralized portal or procurement system as discussed in the following comment.

There is immense value in being part of the customer's procurement application, be it ARIBA, GEP or others. It's important to be part of that, not only for the process transformation but for receiving new leads as well. So, this has smoothened the process of RFP/RFQ sharing, [the] submission of proposals, compliances and quotations, and vendor evaluation. From the sellers' perspective, customer interaction and lead generation happen through this channel as well.

(R11)

4.1.2. Sales Lead engagement support

Second, we found that firms invested heavily in technologies focusing on sales lead engagement support, with four main components (see Table 3). Many organizations provide their salespeople with *support for managing their social media presence and engaging audiences* using relevant content. This support includes access to social media aggregator tools to make organic content visible in the digital channels that typical buying center members or "buyer personas" consume. Our analytical results show that enabling sellers to easily share content ensures that the firm establishes a presence in multiple channels (such as social media sites, industry platforms, B2B review sites, and news outlets); is important for targeting customer segments. The findings are in line with extant literature (Agnihotri et al., 2016); leveraging the personal social network of the employees can increase the organic visibility of the firm generated content; which increases the chances of discovery of the firms and its websites in digital environments (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). This strategy also fosters higher engagement as the following comment notes.

For social media, we have partnered with a company called Oktopost, and there are hosts of similar companies. And what it does is that it gives you an environment ready for posting, sharing content, and even scheduling it. My LinkedIn, Twitter, [and] Facebook are already configured in that Oktopost system. And when I go to Oktopost, you know, the cloud URL, it will already tell me that, you know, here are the contents ready for you to share, if you feel like sharing it. It also allows us to measure the impact of each post or campaign on a dashboard.

(R10)

Our data analysis also shows that organizations widely deploy *tools for sharing personalized content sequences across relevant channels* using marketing automation systems. Lead nurturing aims to achieve higher engagement with leads/prospects through the sharing of sequential, personalized, interlinked content based on buyers' interests or profiles and their actions (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). Marketing automation also allows linking content engagement with other related marketing activities, such as engaging with a blog post may lead to an invitation to attend to a related webinar (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). This allows relevant people to discover information and more deeply investigate topics of interest. The interviewees explained that the process nudges customers to move ahead in their purchase journey; based on its success, salespersons are assigned comment illustrates this.

We help the selling process by doing a lot of automation in case of personalized content sharing, and we keep on optimizing it. So, if we send any content or message to the lead, it may happen that the customer opens it. So, we trigger the other mail, which will be like, you have seen our mail, now this can be [of further use].

(R3)

The interviewees reported that their organizations have invested in systems that help their sales teams collaborate closely with their account-based marketing teams to provide *digital lead nurturing support for strategic accounts*. This activity focuses on personalized engagement with the key stakeholders of strategic accounts and entails developing a buyer's persona before involving the sales team at the opportune time based on engagement success. This practice allows sellers to penetrate these accounts by capitalizing on assistance from the digital marketing team as illustrated in the following comment. The existing literature identifies the value of these activities for the salespersons; as these activities may provide access to the difficult and non-receptive customers and also increases customer's awareness of the provider (Terho, Salonen, & Yrjänen, 2022).

Account-based marketing starts when the marketing team collaborates with [the] sales guy and gets information about 40–50 of [the] choicest accounts. We want to track the decision makers, which places they are visiting and put our advertisement in it. We also send emailers to these accounts, and we give an opportunity to download some content. This allows us to know more about them before mature leads can be handed over to the sales team.

(R6)

Finally, the managers noted the importance of developing market insights for the lead process. This allows sellers to better understand customers and the competitive landscape. Given the abundance of data, some interviewees mentioned the existence of a dedicated analytics team to analyze and consolidate insights from several types of structured and unstructured data. The existing studies have identified three types of data sources for these types of research; internal systems such as CRM and marketing automation; external sources such as social media and market research (Rusthollkarhu et al., 2022)

We have a separate team that helps the sellers [get insights] from so many

diverse types of available data. The chances of selling increase if we tell the customer what she or he doesn't know (R1).

4.1.3. Sales interaction approach guidance

Third, firms invested widely to sales interaction guidance, with three components (see Table 3). Firms offer salespeople tools to collate *buyer persona insights* that go beyond automated lead enrichment. Some firms offer their salespeople technologies to understand each buying unit member's buyer persona as a means to decode their interests and role in the buying process (Grewal & Sridhar, 2021; Huber & Kleinaltenkamp, 2020; Kumar et al., 2024). The findings supplement existing understanding in literature; the organizations use technology to systematically expand listening and understanding cover all members of the buying center members of the firm (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). Identifying different buying center members to learn their traits, preferences, and digital footprints allows salespeople to understand buyers' interests and engage these actors using personalized sales messages as discussed in the following comment.

> *In large deals, multiple people from different departments are often involved. Using LinkedIn Premium and other services, the digital team can track [key people's] social footprint[s] and what they have posted on LinkedIn [and] Facebook. I can know so much about these people without meeting them. All [this] help[s] our salespeople understand the traits and mannerisms of these key people. With these perspectives, our salespersons can customize the sales pitch and deck for them. So, not only do our team [members] know how to contact these people, but they also know how to talk to these important people.*
>
> *(R7)*

Firms also offer *support for consensus building among buying center members.* Sales teams frequently work closely with marketing to build a broader shared understanding of the various stakeholders of the customer organization (see Terho, Mero, et al., 2022), many of whom salespeople have difficulty reaching personally. Accessing relevant content and information through digital channels gives salespeople a broader reach at customer organizations through the ability to create personalized, informative engagement with buying unit members. Knowing these persons allows the organization to send a persuasive message that can create consensus in favor of the seller's organization and even mitigate potentially negative attitudes. In line with literature, we found that, organizations can achieve the same by providing multiple call-to-actions options; such as ask questions through chat, receive another content, participate in any events (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). By providing multiple options of content and information, that aid the buyer personas in their decision making, organizations can be proactive and lead the customer's buying journey (Mero, Tarkiainen, & Tobon, 2020); as highlighted in the below comment.

Even before the first meeting with a customer, we can identify the key people and their traits and interests, what website or social media they spend time on, and what type of content they consume. Our marketing team starts sharing relevant and interesting content [with] these people in the customer's organization. So, all the people important for the deal start getting information about us, based on their information needs and their present journey stages; even before our salespeople actually interact with them. (R15).

The practice of *developing customer interaction strategy* support based on customer analytics is also becoming more common. With this type of AI support, sellers can learn about appropriate sales pitches based on analysis of past interactions, the prospect's background, and the buying stage. Machine learning algorithms analyze multiple ongoing seller–customer interactions and equip sellers with a summary of calls, issues clients have raised, and information about interaction quality. Sellers frequently use this information to fine-tune their interaction approach. In addition to call records, organizations are increasingly using natural language processing techniques to identify important themes and issues in voluminous customer-provided and other social media documents as the following comment demonstrates.

> *[Customers'] calls with sellers are recorded automatically. It helps the sellers and their managers. Based on the analytics, the managers can advise the seller to cut down on their talking time [or] get the customer to speak more and divulge more information.*
>
> *(R15)*

4.1.4. Value proposition communication

The fourth sub-activity of facilitating customer-facing sales interaction focuses on assisting salespeople with value proposition (VP) communication, with three components (See Table 3). Its first component, *support for interactive solution demonstrations*, utilizes technologies that help salespeople communicate the technical superiority of the solutions being offered to the different buying unit members of the customer via demos, trials, and use cases. The interviewees highlighted the need to demonstrate to customers that the solution being offered is technically advanced based on parameters such as ease of implementation, integration feasibility, and operational ease. Allowing customers to access the experience center virtually can increase their confidence in the technical merit and implementation feasibility of futuristic but unproven technologies. The experience center not only demonstrates the implementation of complex, standalone technologies, but it also showcases a complete use case including complementary applications and components available from other partners. For software-as-a-service (SaaS) products, firms give salespeople opportunities to grant their customers trial access to offerings so that they can experience the product features and gain confidence in the offering.

> *So, wherever there is basically any opportunity where you can show something tangible to the customer from either your past projects or something specifically developed for the customer based on your pre-sales stage, that may help to convince the customer sooner. This builds confidence in the customer's mind, as they think this solution probably should work.*
>
> *(R9)*

Value communication tools that provide *support for communicating the value of the proposed solution* using ROI, NPV, business cases, and cost-savings tools are key to enabling salespeople to do their jobs. Many companies provide value calculators so that customers can get an initial idea of the value that would be delivered in terms of saved costs or new revenue. For large customers, sellers can work with the buyer's business team to identify value creation opportunities and then customize the value calculator with these inputs. These digital tools contain pre-integrated information about industry benchmarks and other customers' success stories in similar contexts. The following comment details the benefits.

> *Now, how do you establish the business value of your solutions and ROI to convince the customer that whatever money is being asked is right. To do this, the [customers'] existing data and information about your competitors are fed into our value calculator. And then, think about the comparison or the benchmarking based on the industry and your reference implementations.*
>
> *(R11)*

The last component of VP communication, *global sales team support to augment local sales efforts*, highlights the ease digital technologies bring to holding discussions and negotiations with customers. This ease extends to experts and senior professionals at distant geographic locations. The interviewees mentioned that online collaboration and meeting tools allow them to involve senior experts on other continents, such as Europe and America, in dealings with customers located in Asia and the Middle East, thus avoiding the need for lengthy, unproductive commutes to attend short customer meetings. Additionally, sellers can ask senior executives within their organization, such as the head of delivery or customer operations, to briefly join an online meeting to assure the technical personnel in the client's organization about the seller's

organization's approach and capabilities. In other words, using technology, the sales team can access senior human resources worldwide at the precise moment when their cooperation is crucial to productively capitalize on a sales opportunity. The interviewees also mentioned that even when planning face-to-face meetings with customers, they ensure that the relevant senior executives and experts are available so that they can attend virtually to make the discussion more impactful. The following comment discusses the beneficial use of this technology.

> *In a face-to-face meeting, you cannot take many people with you, but with technology, you can have as many people [as needed] dynamically [participating] in the discussion with customers. I could pull in people from Europe [and] America to have workshops being conducted here without them travelling, which sort of also [gives] us the leverage to involve global talents in conducting sessions [for] the local customers here.*
>
> *(R10)*

4.1.5. Customer value realization

The fifth and final sub-activity of supporting customer-facing sales interaction focuses on facilitating customer value realization, with five components (see Table 3). The interviewees noted that salespeople need digital resources to perform *customer success management and provide value realization support*. Value realization support works in multiple ways. Managers achieve it by providing customers with online resources (i.e., information about features and how they contribute to delivering benefits) related to the modules that have been sold as well as by facilitating customers' interaction with other customers. Online resources can comprise short training, a developer's guide, and other customers' experiences including the problems they have faced. If the buyer needs to develop additional codes to extend the functionality, sellers provide documentation and a programming environment where the buyer's team can learn programming. The following quote explains this well.

> *For cloud customers, our user dashboards tell us about the modules the company has bought but [is] not using. So, if someone has bought the entire thing but is only using some modules, we might lose this customer. We share this particular data regularly with the buyers, the customer success managers and [the] account managers to facilitate interactions. The account managers can suggest methods to increase usage, such as running a campaign or providing training. Besides, we have other online resources for customers, where they can [learn about] other customers' experiences and problems.*
>
> *(R11)*

Our data analysis also shows that many firms provide *tools for communicating the realized value to the customer*. The interviewees highlighted that these components are data-driven and involve the following three steps. First, sellers access metrics on the customer's business and technology performance prior to implementation of the new solution. Second, they derive the financial benefits of adopting the new application (e.g., completed transactions, new customer acquisitions, and campaigns executed); and third, they calculate operational improvements in terms of reduced defects, less user problems, and vendors' improved responsiveness and ability to solve issues. The following comment discusses this practice.

> *Our solution collects different types of data about the website visitors and uses its sophisticated machine learning algorithms to [segment] the visitors. Based on the segment characteristics, website traffic is diverted to different webpages [that showcase] different types of products. We recently worked with a customer and showed them that our solution led to [a] more than 4 times higher conversion rate and a 15 % increase in [the] average order value. Demonstrating the business benefit is a great help for salespeople and often leads to discussion [about] additional licenses.*
>
> *(R26)*

The *customer problem and incident management system for sales* records all reported service usage issues in a central repository, and the applications classify all incidents based on parameters such as priority, urgency, and impact as per the support agreement. The system also links the appropriate service level agreement (SLA) and the time taken to reach a resolution for each reported incident. Although salespeople do not manage individual incidents, aggregate reports and dashboards provide an overview of account health and customer satisfaction, allowing sellers to intervene internally to improve the situation when required. In many cases, the vendor's ability to adhere to SLAs is an important criterion for payment disbursement and the awarding of additional work to the vendor. The following comment discusses this in further detail.

> *The salesperson has information about the major outages in the installed systems. So, system uptime, downtime, SLA reports, and those things are all now available to a seller. Then, the seller is also continuously involved in conducting customer satisfaction surveys. So, these things help the seller gauge how the relationship is progressing, if the customer is satisfied or [if] they are, you know, having some issues in the delivery or ongoing relationship.*
>
> *(R19)*

The practice of *social listening to understand the brand's reputation* refers to the company's ability to listen to customers' opinions and evaluations of products and services via a range of social media and review sites. Continuously listening to social media conversations allows the salespersons to act quickly to address customers' grievances before they snowball into more serious issues and talking points on social media. Electronic word of mouth in the form of customer reviews on popular sites such as Capterrra, G2.com, and TrustRadius are increasingly being used to understand customers' perceptions and past experiences with solution providers. Companies can use these real-time data as an alternative or as a complement to the primary mode of market research aimed at understanding customers' behavior and buying preferences. Salespeople can also use these reviews to reinforce their messages to prospective customers since customers feel assured when the information comes from other buyers rather than from sellers. Our findings extend the established fact that listening is a key requirement for performance improvement for salespersons, but at the same time salespersons cannot take direct inputs provided by the customers at face value (Hinterhuber, 2016). The following comment discusses the use of the tool for understanding customers' point of view.

> *Nowadays, there are different tools which are helpful in online reputation management. You can go there and find out what people are [saying] about your organization. As users' opinion[s] and reviews impact customer[s'] decision[s] [about whether] to go for a brand, the sellers need to know what people are writing about our company, product[s] and services on these platforms.*
>
> *(R18)*

Finally, the interviewees mentioned the growing trend of user analytics-based updates of *ideal customer profiles* to boost future sales. Data may comprise usage data including usage seasonality (i.e., in what season or at what time usage rates rise or fall). Sales data analysis can identify important attributes such as the size of the company, industry, or customer segment, as well as profitability and preference for a specific technology or non-propriety solution, all of which impact deal winning chances. The company can combine these different types of information to develop an ideal customer profile (Kumar et al., 2024) that indicates who is more likely to buy their solutions as discussed in the following comment.

> *As we are a late entrant to the cloud business, our data show that the top 50 accounts in the country do not consider us or call us to participate in the tender process. So, we cannot focus on all customers. [By] synthesizing our internal sales data and customer information with industry*

trends, we can define our ideal customer profile for our sales team to reach out to them more effectively.

(R7)

4.2. Sales enablement in facilitating of internal work efficiency

This second activity dimension of digital sales enablement comprises four sub-activities and their more detailed components as shown in Table 4. These aspects of sales enablement focus on the intra-organizational constituents of sales work aimed at improving the efficiency of sales efforts.

4.2.1. Optimize Lead nurturing resources in Lead nurturing

The goal of optimizing and prioritizing resources explains the application of digital technologies to the automation of routine sales tasks and the allocation of sales resources through data-driven lead qualification. It consists of three components (see Table 4). Given customers' preference for omnichannel interactions, the *automated scheduling of sales meetings* with customers ensures that sellers lose minimal productive time planning and organizing online meetings. Even when meetings are offline, meeting planners can ensure sellers' maximum productivity through efficient planning that avoids having sellers travel back and forth to the same location and idling between meetings. Meeting automation also considers the customer's preference of the meeting time and channel. Interviewees also noted that because online interactions with customers are recorded, sellers and their managers can instantly access a summary of the discussion and gauge customer sentiment regarding the interactions to decide the next step.

In addition to automating sales meeting planning and scheduling, interviewees highlighted an increasing trend of *automating routine prospecting and lead management tasks (*Rusthollkarhu et al., 2022). While the extant sales enablement literature due to its conceptual nature does not cover these activities; our study's findings are similar to studies that have investigated AI's role in sales process, such as analyzing the need for a meeting, automatic meeting scheduling, transcription of meeting and business calls and providing suggestions for next steps for proceeding with a customer (Rusthollkarhu et al., 2022). In our study, sellers mentioned the huge convenience of automated data entry where customer interactions are entered into CRM and other systems without sellers' active involvement. In addition to the productivity gains, automation allows sellers to focus on value-added activities such as spending more time with customers and also reduces the possibilities of incompleteness or inaccuracies in the CRM data (Singh et al., 2019). Consider the following illustrative quote:

Sales engagement tools have encapsulated many features to help salespeople with activities such as lead generation, demand generation, meeting planning and other regular sales stuff. So, you can run a campaign and analyze the sentiment of the responses. For email response [s], the software will check the responses and schedule a meeting with customers [with a] positive set of responses.

(R22)

The managers we interviewed also mentioned *analytics-based lead scoring and prioritization* to help salespeople identify the best leads and improve the effectiveness of the prospecting process. For digital leads, firms use a lead scoring model based on multiple parameters such as the prospect's online interest or behavior (e.g., attending a webinar may get a higher score than clicking on a blog), and perceived buying stage (e.g., a prospect clicking a pricing sheet is more favorably rated than somebody reading product features). Our findings support the existing literature on developing a lead scoring model for digital opportunities, engagement with firm generated content is one of the key inputs for developing the same and multiple buyer personas' lead score can be aggregated to do lead scoring at the customer level (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022).

Many firms use machine learning-based predictive techniques to perform these tasks with a large number of predictors (e.g., opportunity size, profit margin, customer details, industry, and geographical location) from their historical datasets (Syam & Sharma, 2018). Interviewees noted that other than predicting the chances of winning a deal, this type of analysis reveals the factors that impact the chances of winning.

Our in-house AI-based system works on both deals and leads; it will tell you how likely your opportunity will [be to] convert. The prediction is based on historical data. We have been in business for 18 years now, and the tool, the technology or the logic behind [it] is that it is, you know, checking 18 years' worth of data and using more than 200 inputs to provide us with the prediction.

(R10)

4.2.2. Design value proposition

The second sub-activity of internal work efficiency, VP design, has three components (see Table 4). The first component, *harvesting and reusing assets in proposal development* entails applying technology to develop a compelling proposal that includes a value proposition, a business case, technical and commercial solution, and supporting evidence such as case studies (Rangarajan et al., 2020). Large organizations also provide access to past solutions, templates, videos, case studies, and other types of content harvested from their multiple sales and delivery engagements. All these contents and assets are electronically available to sellers after removing the client-specific references. Knowledge management systems facilitate updates and additions and easy searches of existing assets, allowing the proposal development team to easily access the right content with minimum effort. Pre-integration with a CRM reduces the complexity of the proposal development process while increasing its uniformity, quality, and efficiency – see below quote.

The entire repository [for managing other people's knowledge and experience] is available at the click of a button. You have templates readily available. You have executive summaries, for instance, written by somebody else somewhere across the globe. So, you can actually go into the dashboard [and see] the proposals which we have submitted [and] the proposals that we have actually won versus lost. The data-driven approach makes it easier when we are approaching customers.

(R5)

Competitor benchmarking information for sales proposals equips sellers with comparative information about the features and benefits offered by their products and solutions compared to similar solutions offered by competitors (see Hossain et al., 2022). A comparative analysis based on features provided enough pointers to the sellers about their points of parities, points of differences and where they fall behind their competitors, as the following comment demonstrates.

There are so many companies offering the same thing these days. There are tools to do comparative analysis. It starts comparing competitors' options and gives information to use during a sales call

(R22)

Solution configuration support for effective customization and sizing complements proposal development. For less complex SaaS products, there is an increasing trend towards self-configuration. Customers can access videos, guidelines, and suggested configurations and do not need a salesperson's intervention for initial configuration and sizing. For complex products, sales support tools gather information from the customer as the discussion progresses. Regarding cloud transformation opportunities, in addition to solution sizing, tools are increasingly being used to calculate resource requirements and desired skillsets as the following comment demonstrates.

For SaaS products, no dedicated customer support team would be available to customize the product for their usage. The template of what the

customer is signing up for is already preloaded with so many different configurations. So, as a user, you will get access to videos and guides and so on. This information is automatically updated to an internal portal, where salespeople can use [it] to plan their interventions.

(R23)

4.2.3. Coordination and collaboration

The third sub-activity of internal work efficiency with five components (see Table 4) explains the application of digital resources to give sellers access to information that they can use to coordinate effectively within and outside the sales organization (Singh et al., 2019). Organizations have widely increased their investment in establishing *a centralized content platform to facilitate content sharing and easy access to content* (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). Instead of burdening salespeople with the task of developing high-quality content, digital content is created through collaborations involving domain expertise, legal expertise, ethical compliance, and digital marketing skills. For effectively engaging with customers, literature suggests the need of developing two types of contents; i) content that provides visionary perspectives on business themes b) content that addresses customer's specific information need and the need to synthesize these contents (Terho, Mero, et al., 2022). As content creation has become a more organized, centralized activity, organizations are using digital platforms to organize and store developed, validated content. These digital platforms make content easy to access and can also search and customize for every customer as the following comment shows.

Sellers today have professionally developed content available and easily accessible from internal platforms, which helps them to initiate conversations with the customers at the senior level. With constant advances in technology, search and identification of specific content [have] become much more salesperson friendly.

(R9)

Many organizations are also providing ongoing *content optimization support to improve customer engagement*. This quality optimization process creates relevant, interesting content that establishes the seller as an expert in the customer's eyes. The goal is to attract decision makers' attention in the midst of a plethora of available content. The interviewees mentioned that data from web analytics tools and internal testing such as A/B testing allow their technical team to identify the best-performing content for a specific medium as indicated in the following comment.

Initially, you need to test all these contents and only then can you identify the best content. The sales team may not be able to do that, or they do not have the time to do so. So, they will depend on [the] marketing team. So, we test specific content on different platforms like LinkedIn [and] Blogs YouTube and see which platform [combined with] which content is more effective. We would then provide this intelligence to the sales team.

(R18)

Pipeline status visibility to enhance sales team collaboration helps sellers who are working on multiple customer opportunities and are at different stages of negotiating each opportunity. For a qualified opportunity, the organization supports sellers by forming a multi-functional internal team. As the team members are drawn from different geographies, manual follow-ups and status updates are difficult. A centralized digital tool allows sellers to remain apprised of the statuses of multiple opportunities online and identify the present activity and the person assigned to that activity for each one (see Hunter, 2019). In addition to information availability, this allows the seller, as the opportunity owner, to intervene, when necessary, as shown in the following comment.

For developing a proposal, a large number of people are involved within our organization. These individuals are constantly involved with multiple opportunities with multiple salespeople. As a salesperson, I am also involved in a couple of different discussions. However, I need to track the progress of any specific proposal. For that, I need to see the workflow to know what exactly is happening with my opportunity, and having a pipeline tool with clear visibility makes it easier for me.

(R2)

The emergence of *technology-assisted deal closing* highlights digital technologies' role in assisting sellers with closing a deal by completing the necessary technical documentation and contracting work in the last phase of negotiation (Rustholllkarhu et al., 2022). This activity helps organization in the contract signing and analysis process; in addition, AI can identify risky clauses and offers suggestions to replace them (Rustholllkarhu et al., 2022). The interviewees mentioned that sellers have access to standard statements of work and contracts, which they can quickly modify to develop the final customer-specific documents. Instead of emailing, the internal system can share the relevant contract and scope documents with the various stakeholders involved in the process. The system also allows review by multiple people concurrently and stores the review comments for easy traceability. The finalized documents can even be signed digitally and shared with the relevant people. The following comment discusses why this is beneficial.

Negotiation is an iterative process and requires human intervention, but contracting as a service has already started getting into automation with companies like DocuSign hav[ing] minimized the necessity of human intervention. Second is the reusability of the contract across customers with similar demands. The sellers just need to insert the necessary parameters for a specific customer, and you have the necessary documentation ready.

(R22)

Technology is also increasingly used in the internal process of *effective deal handover from the sales team to the post-sales solution delivery team* (Hunter, 2019). A proper handover to the implementation team is a prerequisite for committed value delivery, which, in turn, enhances the seller's ability to forge a profitable, long-term relationship with the buyer. Because sellers are the personnel who are primarily involved in multiple discussions with the client's leadership team, transferring all documented and tacit knowledge to the delivery team is crucial. Technology allows the selling organization to share all customer communication, customer-provided documents, documents shared with customers, and other insights digitally, and doing so confirms the authenticity and completeness of the information shared. The digital transfer also excludes all informal communication from the delivery scope. Hence, technology-driven handover makes the process transparent, provides the delivery team with all the necessary information, and makes the sales team accountable for any informal commitment to the buyer. This also allows the sales team to avoid multiple handover processes to different persons or teams in the delivery organization.

I think if the process of [transitioning a] customer relationship from the sales guy to the delivery guy is managed properly, it can actually solve so many problems. A documenting tool always helps to keep the salespeople honest and prevents them from [doing] anything that is non-compliant. Timely delivery, expectation management, customer retention, [and] customer excellence, are all dependent on this. It's a very important digitally enabled process in the post-sales context.

(R11)

4.2.4. Account growth and retention

The fourth sub-activity of internal work efficiency (see Table 4) has five components. Many firms use AI-based technologies to derive *insights for account planning* (Singh et al., 2019). These insights can be related to projections about revenue from an account and customers' propensity to buy from a supplier. Interviewees mentioned that instead of depending solely on historical revenue, AI-based systems can consider multiple additional factors such as modules customer bought but are not used,

industry trends, customer growth plans, knowledge of the local sales and account management teams, and social media discussions. The system can then develop revenue projections and predict important customers' propensity to buy from a seller.

> *Organizations collate all information about their customers (particularly for cloud customers) and put [it] in a single analytical platform. The information can be related to the delivery status of the components already bought. We also know white spaces; the modules and solutions customers have not bought [and] the modules the customer has bought but not used completely or effectively. Technology allows visibility of all that information in a single system, [and] its analytical brain [can also] synthesize this information with past trends, information from the account team, and the [customer] growth plan.*
>
> *(R2)*

Customer analytics-driven cross-, up-, and re-selling initiatives help salespeople engage with customers to create up- and cross-selling opportunities. Firms offer their salespeople information about customers' product usage and share the results of customer satisfaction surveys. To effectively position an extended solution, sellers also access the usage information of other reference customers in similar industries. Additionally, sellers push analytics and machine learning solutions to complement the main functionality of any module. An analytical add-on solution gives buyers insights and makes sense of the data other systems generate. The following comment discusses the benefits of this.

> T*he bigger challenge is looking at the existing usage and positioning the up sale in the right manner. Positioning the up sale is difficult [when] they are not using the products they have bought, and that is the next area that we are trying to explore with usage data and industry benchmarks. We also use tools to map the customer against the best of the breed in the same industry vertical. So, comparing with those benchmarks can give us the white spacing, and that also helps the sales guys in the field go to the customer and talk about the right customer solutions.*
>
> *(R10)*

Organizations have also deployed *analytics-based customer retention and churn management support* to identify high-risk customers and improve the retention of valuable customers (Singh et al., 2019; Syam & Sharma, 2018). Today's sellers and account management teams can access multiple indicators to identify customers who might not renew their subscriptions and are likely to churn out. A sales leader at a digital payment collection and disbursement company explained it as follows.

> *We do churn analysis [using] leading indicators of churn. If we see the volume or usage in any payment mode is dropping, this means that the customer might be using the competition to get their jobs done. In this case, the likelihood of the churn happening is very high. So, you need to see indicators and take pre-emptive action on that.*
>
> *(R23)*

Related to the previously discussed component, customer usage *analytics-driven sales growth forecasting* allows sellers to propose innovative commercial proposals that ensure their customers' long-term commitment (Kumar et al., 2024). The seller's customer success team has access to information about the capacity customers utilize across the different modules the company offers. Information about peak usage and the time when this occurs (e.g., a particular day or month or time of day) is also accessible. Historical capacity utilization and seasonality data can be used to understand buyers' future cloud demand as discussed in the following comment.

> *If you want to analyze usage data or if you want to see the trend[s], our analytic cloud is awesome. I mean, based on the last 3 years' consumption of any cloud-based application, we are easily able to predict any customer's demand for the next year. The analysis takes into account the seasonality factors and [the] account-specific factors. The good thing for our customers [is that] we have all the data about the systems they have bought and how they are using it. This gives the account team enough information to negotiate for the additional capacity at the right price.*
>
> *(R11)*

While customer success and more business from existing accounts are critical; the last component explains the ease of raising and tracking invoices and the ability to track the payment realizations digitally. *Effective payment realization support* for served customers provides multiple types of invoicing criteria including achievement of milestones and periodical (time-based) or fulfillment of SLAs. Although finance personnel raise invoices and collect payments, sellers can track an account's financial health and intervene as needed. When there are disputes, sellers need to engage with the customers to seek resolutions and collect payment.

> *Invoicing and payment realization are also happening online via portals. Once the sign-off of the deliverables is done, we log in to these portals and generate the invoice. In many cases, customers and sellers are in different countries, and as a result, it saves lots of time for everybody. The same thing also works in other scenarios, where the payment happens at regular intervals based on achieving certain criteria and SLAs. Though operations people do invoice raising, the salespeople are responsible for all three aspects of booking, billing and collection. Digital technologies make it convenient to track that the money has been deposited in the service provider's bank account.*
>
> *(R4)*

4.3. Sales enablement in facilitating capability enhancement

The third capability enhancement -activity comprises three sub-activities and seven components (Table 5). The sub-activities center on aiding salespeople's development of new capabilities and enhancing their capabilities on an ongoing basis (Rangarajan et al., 2020; Rapp & Beeler, 2021).

4.3.1. Effective on-boarding

The first sub-activity, effective on-boarding, aims to provide new sales talent with access to organizational resources, information, and sales tools to fast track their ramp-up time and boost their productivity (CSO Insights, 2016). This sub-activity consists of only one component (see Table 5): *On-boarding tools to shorten new salespeople's ramp-up time.* Interviewees noted that the technology-enabled on-boarding process helps organizations to speed up granting access to multiple databases and tools; eliminate the need for periodic in-classroom salesperson training. Instead, new sellers can access information about their clients, the company's products, and the markets via centralized portals at any time. This renders the necessary knowledge available at the opportune moment as depicted in the following quote.

> *Basically, it's not about learning from PowerPoint files or learning in the classrooms anymore. You can actually push the entire on-boarding content to a new hire as a self-paced learning program which can be conducted using the LMS (learning management system).*
>
> *(R16)*

4.3.2. Coaching and performance management

The coaching and performance management theme has two key components (see Table 5). *Proactive sales management coaching aims to boost salespeople's productivity* by increasing the application of digital technology-driven insights to coaching and motivation (CSO Insights, 2016) and ensuring that the coaching initiatives are tailored to each individual salesperson (Rangarajan et al., 2020). Sales management applications and CRMs have built-in analytics and can therefore continuously provide managers with multiple indicators related to sellers' performance for comparison to their set targets and their peers' performance. This system also identifies the leads a given seller is

currently handling and provides detail about the phases and aging. These analytics give managers multiple pointers (see Peterson et al., 2021) that are useful in proactive coaching, such as the likelihood of sellers achieving their targets, recommended actions for sellers to pursue for achieving their goals, and the specific areas in which salespeople who are experiencing challenges might need guidance or coaching.

> *So, the tools we use have analytic capability, and they provide alarm[s] and indicators. The sales leader can go through every opportunity and also access summary information and [the] overall status for a seller. The manager can drill down to [the] deal level and even look at sales interactions and see the status. The manager can focus on those opportunities which have not been progressing for a long time and can intervene to help [that] particular seller.*
>
> *(R13)*

Additionally, with technology-assisted *target setting and incentive disbursement support*, (Rapp & Beeler, 2021) managers highlighted two aspects. Online tools bring more transparency to target and incentive setting as well as to monitoring and disbursement. Further, more complex parameters can now be included in incentive design to promote the sale of services and products offered by other divisions or business units within the seller's organization. The sellers can be offered a higher commission when they successfully sell new offerings, and salespeople are also rewarded for cross-selling when a customer buys services or products from other business units within a seller's organization. The following comment describes these benefits.

> *Actually, the process of setting targets and sharing benefits with salespersons has become extremely streamlined. All these complex incentive structures are seamlessly controlled and managed. The incentive and target setting, and benefit distribution process[es] have become more transparent.*
>
> *(R4)*

4.3.3. Knowledge and skills acquisition

Finally, firms widely used knowledge and skills acquisition consisting of four components for capacity enhancement (see Table 5). The first component of this sub-activity is associated with the ease of planning and tracking and the execution of *customized, self-paced learning for salespeople* (Guenzi & Habel, 2020; Harney et al., 2019). Sales enablement literature suggests that the success of sales enablement depends largely on continual training and learning of the employees (Rangarajan et al., 2020). Based on the specific job role, an employee can develop a personal learning plan and a timeline to achieve their goals. Learning management applications remind employees about their pending learning goals, and based on their evaluated skills and knowledge, the applications can also recommend additional knowledge areas or courses. These tools also provide managers with snapshots of individual employees' learning-related performance. Learning applications allow everyone to customize their learning at a pace and time suited to them. The level of knowledge can also be adjusted to suit the person's background, making continuous learning achievable. The following comment explains this.

> *[While] the person is learning the necessary processes, the system [tracks their progress]. Otherwise, the tool will keep nudging salespeople to complete the learning process. You can make your own plan [and choose] what additional things you want to get trained, when you want to get trained, how you want to get trained and the content that you like. There is also help or support on demand when you get stuck.*
>
> *(R15)*

The second component, *developing digital lead management skillsets,* focuses on assessing and monitoring salespeople's skills and encouraging skills sharing among salespeople to keep the sales force's knowledge of lead management best practices up to date (Guenzi & Habel, 2020). Lead management is among the areas that digital technologies and data impact the most because companies use multiple tools to help salespeople with this task. Digital enablement offers salespeople intuitive guidance, steers the workflow to the appropriate tools, and offers new ways of using these tools. The finding highlights the growing trend of peer coaching; where top performers and early adopters can share their experiences with new tactics, tools with the entire organization in both formal and informal context (Rangarajan et al., 2020).

> *We are continuously evaluating new tools for lead management, even how to make the best use of the existing tools. The focus is on how we can make practical use of these tools. Like, for example, if you integrate your LinkedIn with CRM, so much information can be gathered, and that will be a much more intelligent approach for approaching your customer. Now, people are integrating their CRMs with ChatGPT because they allow them to write better emails. We work together with salespeople to find innovative ways to reach their customers using LinkedIn, [by] organizing webinars, or whatever else is needed.*
>
> *(R1)*

The third component, *learning from lost leads*, entails gaining insights from lost opportunities to improve the sales organization's effectiveness. Analytics can reveal important insights and highlight areas of concern. These are then fed into the sales process and can be used to improve the impacted areas (Hossain et al., 2022). Organizations can also use this information to target customers with a certain profile and increase salespeople's likelihood of success.

> *Traditionally, companies put postponed sales, dormant sales, and lost sales on [the] back burner, [but] companies are realizing [that these are] a goldmine [and are] investing in the analysis of lost sales. They are learning from it; [they learn] why they are losing and [then they] cycle [that knowledge] back into the sales process so that salespersons can be more effective.*
>
> *(R22)*

The fourth component is the *feedback-based optimization of lead nurturing approaches*. The optimization process uses CRM data about leads' end states alongside feedback from the sales team based on their customer interactions. The analysis focuses on findings patterns; examples of patterns might be discovering that leads with a particular profile are easier or harder to convert. The marketing team can modify and improve the rules of engagement and launch campaigns to weed out difficult leads and ultimately achieve a higher lead conversion rate. Our study operationalizes the existing agreement in the literature; marketing, sales and inside sales functions should jointly develop lead management processes, internal service-level agreements and the associated terminologies (Terho, Salonen, & Yrjänen, 2022).

> *We frequently [have discussions] with sales to review if we can improve the ratio of marketing qualified leads (MQLs) to sales qualified leads (SQL) and [have] more SQLs converted to actual deals. For nurturing, we use multiple rules and logics at the backend, which contains lots of intelligence. How do we weed out non-serious leads? What type of content should be sent to the leads in different stages? How frequently should it be sent? What should be the call to action? How many times a week should we send emails to them? What time of the day should we send the mail?*
>
> *(R3)*

4.4. Digital sales enablement framework

The first results Sections 4.1–4.3 presented the digital sales enablement functions, that is, how organizations can use digital technologies to enable the sales force. This fourth results Section 4.4 reports the more advanced findings concerning how and when the digital enablement could result in sales performance along the sales process. Specifically, to deepen the insights on digital sales enablement, this last results section

summarizes the findings concerning the a) the key functions of digital sales enablement along the sales process, b) its likely performance outcomes and c) key contingency factors that might impact the performance relationship of digital sales enablement initiatives. The digital sales enablement framework presented in Fig. 1. summarizes these outcome-focused findings. We discuss the key results in detail in sections below.

4.4.1. Understanding digital sales enablement functions along the sales process

First, we deepened the analysis on digital sales enablement by analyzing closer how its functions manifest along the B2B sales process. Since sales process research has challenged the validity of linear "seven steps of selling" (Moncrief & Marshall, 2005), we adopt broader view to sales process stages, aligned with customer journey conceptualizations, including pre-approach, sales negotiations, and value delivery and relationship management. Our investigation shows that digital sales enablement can be impactful in all stages of the sales process (Fischer et al., 2022). Yet, as summarized in Tables 3,4 and 5, the data analysis indicated that the 2nd -order themes, that is sub-activities of digital sales enablement manifest differently along the different stages of the sales process. The "three digital sales enablement functions along the sales process" -box in Fig. 1 highlights the juxtaposition of our research findings on the different stages of the B2B sales process. We find that digital sales enablement supports activities specific to a particular sales process in a specific sales stage (such as lead qualification in lead and pre-approach phase) and activities which are not confined to a specific sales stage (such as coaching and knowledge acquisition). The findings provide structured insights into how digital sales enablement initiatives impact on salespeople's ability to deal with different challenges arising along the sales process.

4.4.2. Perceived performance outcomes of digital sales enablement

Second, our study further focused on understanding how the sales process facilitation relates to performance. The interviewees widely perceived that their digital sales enablement facilitated salesperson sales process efficiency and effectiveness, thereby having the potential to impact positively multiple areas of firm performance (Fig. 1), as illustrated by the below power quote:

> *Sales enablement will ensure primarily two things: First, it makes the sales process efficient, and second, it brings a lot of consistency to the whole process. So, the demonstrated benefit would come in terms of improved productivity of the salespeople. Ideally, the revenue generated per salesperson would increase once the sales enablement is put into place, but it is not the only thing; [rather, it is] one part of the entire set of benefits. Sales enablement enables your salespeople to communicate with your customers effectively. So, there would be indirect benefits in terms of better customer relationships.*
>
> *(R1)*

These findings align well with the related research in this area. Work by Rodriguez et al. (2016) suggest that building capabilities of salespeople has an impact both on their ability to build customer relationships and thereby sales performance. Peterson and Dover (2020) further propose that enabling the sales force has an impact on the sales performance by reducing stress levels experienced by salespeople. By combining the insight from empirical findings and extant sales research, we call for explanatory research linking digital sales enablement to four areas of outcome performance, that is, salesperson selling performance, salesperson job stress and satisfaction, customer relationship performance, and organizational performance.

4.4.3. Digital sales enablement contingency factors

Third, to deepen the empirical findings on the relationship between

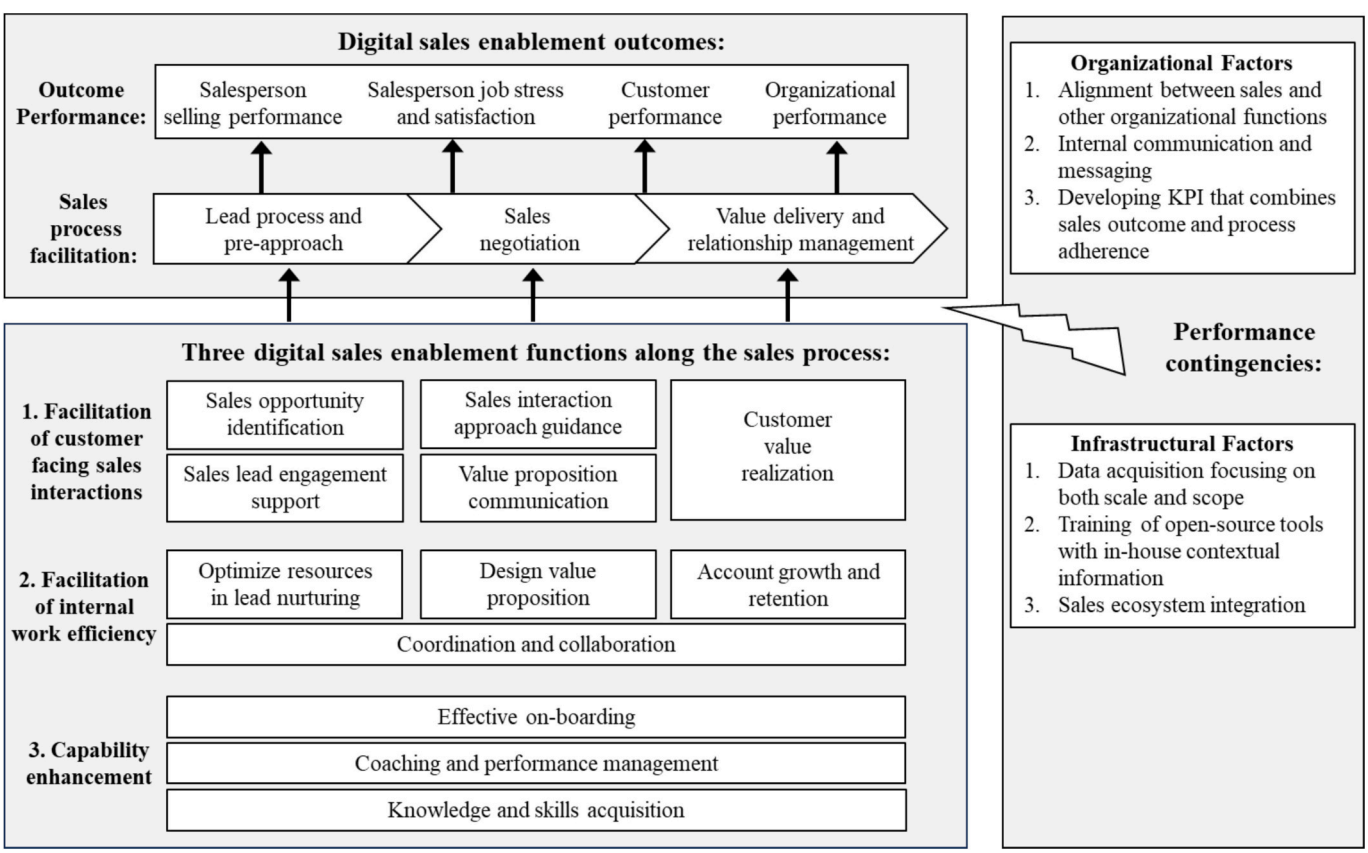

Fig. 1. Digital sales enablement framework: key functions along the sales process, outcomes and contingency factors.

digital sales enablement and performance we analyzed further the key contingency factors that are likely to impact the proposed performance relationship. The data analysis indicated two major groups of contingencies, namely organizational and infrastructural factors affecting the performance relationship as illustrated in performance contingencies -box in Fig. 1. We discuss the identified contingencies below.

4.4.4. Organizational contingency factors

The organizational contingency factors highlight that effective sales enablement deployment needs close collaboration between multiple functions of the organization as well as effective internal communication. We identify three organizational contingencies (see Fig. 1).

4.4.4.1. Alignment between sales and other organizational functions. Effective deployment of sales enablement focuses on providing salespeople with the right type of information and support at the opportune time to allow them to engage effectively with leads and customers. With the increasing use of technologies, applications deployed to achieve the above goals are not always under sales organizations' control. For example, the marketing function's relative contribution to in identifying, enriching, and nurturing leads have increased in recent years, due to higher dependence on digital marketing for lead management activities. In turn, contract renewal and up- and cross-selling depend on insights gained via applications that are managed by the project, operations, and customer success teams. A similar level of embeddedness exists for pricing, technical solutions, procurement, and other internal functions in terms of effectively managing different aspects of sales activity. Overall, Sales enablement strategy focuses on leveraging the entire organization's assets in maximizing revenue (Rangarajan et al., 2020). In line with this, the interviewees stressed that sales enablement requires cross-functional coordination and a feedback mechanism, such as sales operation teams to orchestrate the required alignments throughout the organization (Peterson & Dover, 2020; Westbrook & Peterson, 2020):

> *Sales enablement is a function that connects not just sales and marketing but also customer success, operations, and finance with the salespeople, even with procurement and other functions. So basically, what happens is, right, let us say there is a negotiation with the customer, so salespersons have to work with the finance and pricing people. Sales enablement would allow everybody to be taken together in a transparent and consistent manner instead of salespersons directly going to [the] finance people in an ad hoc manner. It also ensures that the salespeople, finance team, and pre-sales [team] are on the same page as far as what we need to [tell] the customer.*
>
> *(R1)*

4.4.4.2. Internal communication and messaging. Salespeople are independent by nature and do not always follow processes meticulously. Many view the use of excessive technologies as managers' attempts to control their activities, which reduces their independence and increases overhead (Johnson & Bharadwaj, 2005; Micallef et al., 2024). Overall while technology-enabled digital enablement deployment leads to multiple productivity and other benefits; salespeople and sales managers also face negative consequences (Micallef et al., 2024). As a result, the sales managers face dual challenges to increase acceptance and adoption of the sales enablement initiatives (Blut & Wang, 2020), while ensuring adequate return on investment (Micallef et al., 2024).

The interviewees noted that management can use different approaches to ensure buy-ins from sellers. On the one hand, management should articulate the value of sales enablement in terms of increasing salespeople's efficiency and effectiveness. Interviewees also stressed the necessity of encouraging knowledge sharing among salespeople while reducing the procedural burden on them by automating the upload, analysis, and summarization of online customer interactions and providing support and on-demand help to those salespeople who are struggling to use the systems related to sales enablement effectively.

> *Sellers don't get paid [for] getting trained or entering [the] right kind of data into the systems, right? Salespeople get the commission on what they are selling. And even if we tell them that, you know, these are new courses that will help you [with] selling, they will rather spend their time looking for [a] new customer, [a] new prospect, [or] new deals, which will bring them a bigger paycheck. We need to put some kind of carrot and stick in place to motivate them. [For the carrot,] you can show them the benefits of using the tools and ask some of the early adopters to share their experiences. We also make available micro-learning resources, which are short and very specific to one topic. [We also need] some kind of stick that if it goes beyond [a] certain date or deadline or you're not meeting those criteria, then there are some consequences.*
>
> *(R10)*

4.4.4.3. Developing KPI combining revenue and non-revenue outcomes. The interviewees suggested that sales enablement leaders need to develop KPIs keeping in mind multiple objectives: a) addressing diverse types of roles within the sales enablement function (Peterson & Munoz, 2024), b) increasing adoption of sales enablement infrastructure and processes, c) integrating the role of other functions (such as marketing, procurement) in sales enablement. Traditional KPIs are focused on the revenue-related outcomes or results expected from salespeople (e.g., number of closed deals, quota attainment, and up and cross-sell outcomes). The sales enablement deployment would call for developing additional non-revenue-based metrics (Peterson & Munoz, 2024) (e.g., content usage analytics, sales cycle length, seller onboarding time, and process adherence ratio) (Peterson et al., 2021). Effectively designing and implementing these metrics would prompt the appropriate salespersons' behavior in adopting the sales enablement framework and also help in measuring the success of cross-functional sales enablement efforts (CSO Insights, 2016).

> *Sales enablement allows sellers to get real help from other function[s] and teams, either content management, digital marketing, learning, [or] procurement. So, enablement metrics should be aligned with cross-functional objectives, measuring the success of [the] sales effort and the support functions. It is absolutely necessary to involve these functions effectively and fine-tune them.*
>
> *(R1)*

4.4.5. Infrastructural contingency factors

The infrastructural contingency factors highlight that the speed and effectiveness of sales enablement deployment can be ensured using data, ecosystems and technology (Guenzi & Habel, 2020; Rustholllkarhu et al., 2022). We identify three infrastructural contingencies (see Fig. 1).

4.4.5.1. Data acquisition focusing on both scale and scope. Many of the interviewees highlighted the increasing importance of data to sales-related decision-making. Basing sales decisions on data has largely replaced the earlier method of intuitive or group-based decision-making process. However, to leverage the increased availability of useful data, organizations must ensure that internal and external data are collected, cleaned, and made available to relevant applications on a continuous basis and without delay (Harney et al., 2019; Hossain et al., 2022). The interviewees mentioned harnessing the scale and scope of the data. Increasing the scale or volume is achieved by consolidating data about more customers or more opportunities. The scope of the data increases with the gathering of varied information about customers or leads. As the scope widens, the value of the data for decision-making increases. The interviewees also mentioned that salespeople frequently ignore leads that cannot be converted and quickly move to new opportunities in an effort to achieve their targets, which results in the loss of data about

missed sales that have the potential to provide great insight into the sales models.

> *Whenever you pick up the phone and make a call, you can hit the record button, and it'll go directly into the CRM system. In real-time, you can add your comments. One of the core features [is] that CRM is integrated with your Microsoft Outlook. From there, you can push any email, contact, or meeting into the CRM system. So, you know, those kind[s] of things help the data entry part. But for the leads that were not converted and the customer[s] who have churned, we have not [found] a good solution. Sellers do not like to spend time on these to capture lots of details. Right. So, sales operations and marketing operations reach these customers or leads… Sometimes, we give some bonuses so that those people, so that they respond to our survey and information requests. This is to do a deeper analysis of our losses [to find out] why we are losing and how we can avoid that.*
>
> *(R10)*

4.4.5.2. Training open-source tools using in-house contextual information. Sales enablement deployment is increasingly relying on generative AI tools to help salespeople identify the best collateral for a sales activity or develop an initial sales pitch. These tools are also being used to develop training content for salespeople. The analytical models behind these tools are often trained using generic data that are available in the public domain. Consequently, the outcomes may be too generic and unspecific to an organization's customers, industry context, or cumulative experiences. Some of the managers we interviewed, including the one quoted below, suggested that these general open-source tools should be further trained on in-house historical business data.

> *There are lots of discussions about ChatGPT and how our salespeople are benefitting, but in large organizations [with] analytical capabilities, like us, there [is] lots of work going on with open-source generative AI. These models are already trained with large datasets, primarily sourced from [the] internet. Our analytics team fine-tunes it with our in-house business data. Access to in-house data provides more contextual insight [because] the algorithm learns from our customers and our way of doing business.*
>
> *(R25)*

Our analysis brings out the nuances of making larger quantity of information available to salespersons. Additional information can increase sales conversion and aid in better decision making; but also leads to concern about the quality of the information, while sales leaders are also worried about sharing more amount of information with salespersons (Micallef et al., 2024).

4.4.5.3. Sales ecosystem integration. The interviewees stressed the need for application- and process-level integration with partners to reap the full benefits of the use of digital technologies in sales enablement deployment. Organizations are increasingly working with partners to sell and deliver appropriate value-propositions to buyers (Stonig et al., 2022). Interviewees mentioned various types of collaboration with ecosystem partners, such as solution development, establishing contracting and billing mechanisms, managing ongoing customer relationships, and providing services, including consultancy, migration, deployment, and operation support. All these require syncing with the partners' processes and granting the partners access to ecosystem leaders' sales and commercial applications when required. The interviewees suggested that organizations should carefully consider how to integrate their sales and commercial processes and tools with their important partners to facilitate the leveraging of digital technologies in sales enablement deployment and achieve faster automated processes involving less manual work.

> *We act as resellers and value-added service providers for AWS and Azure… We also provide billing services to the local customers. That allows the customers to pay in [their] local currency and reduces the chances of non-payment for AWS. We have access to customer usage of the subscribed cloud services to raise bills and collect payments. As part of their sales strategies, the large cloud players [financially] incentivize migration to their cloud platform. We have shared information about customer usage after migration so that the financial benefits are transferred to customers and partners like us only when additional usage is achieved, making it a win-win for all.*
>
> *(R12)*

5. Discussion

5.1. Theoretical implications

The B2B sales environment has been in flux during recent years due to suppliers' move towards increasingly complex offerings, customers' changing buying behavior as they become more informed and empowered, and related technological developments. Taken together, these changes mean that salespeople face increasing, multifaceted demands that are hard for individuals acting alone to meet. Many B2B sales organizations have recognized these challenges and have responded by investing in broad, cross-functional organizational support to help salespeople engage in value-adding sales dialogue with their customers. However, research in this area is still emerging and has mainly focused on understanding what "organizational sales enablement" (see Peterson & Dover, 2020; Rangarajan et al., 2020) entails conceptually; much less is known about what the deployment of these initiatives means at sales process level and what role fast-developing digital technologies play in this context. Our research sheds new light on these knowledge gaps and makes four novel contributions to the emerging sales enablement literature.

First, the study extends the nascent sales enablement literature (e.g., Peterson & Dover, 2021; Rangarajan et al., 2020) by focusing on sales enablement deployment, that is, how firms successfully implement sales enablement initiatives at the operational, sales process level. Prior research has provided valuable but abstract conceptualizations of sales enablement as a dynamic capability building on three components of insight triangulation, enablement infrastructure, and sales support development (Peterson & Dover, 2020). Our research provides rich, novel insights into how the sales enablement infrastructure, comprising the sales conduit and enablement systems, can be deployed to support sales processes through digital technologies. Specifically, our results demonstrate how the three digital sales enablement functions and their associated activities help translate sales enablement into customer-facing frontline selling practices. In doing so, this study makes an important conceptual "delineating contribution" (see MacInnis, 2011) by developing a digital sales enablement framework that outlines three key salesperson-focused digital sales enablement functions of customer-facing sales interactions, internal work efficiency and coordination, and capability enhancement and their more specific activities. Arguably, the framework helps to understand how firms can deploy the dynamic sales enablement capabilities into sales practice through reconfiguring and enhancing different types of organization-wide resources (such as informational, relational, organizational and human resources – see Morgan, 2012) with the help of digital sales enablement functions and activities at frontline sales process level (see Girod & Whittington, 2017).

Second, our study provides new insights into the role of using digital technologies for deploying sales enablement initiatives into practice in sales organizations when selling complex solutions. Although a growing body of studies have investigated technology use in sales (Guenzi & Habel, 2020; Rusthollkarhu et al., 2022), ours is among the first to analyze the phenomenon in the sales enablement context. Thus, our empirically based conceptualization work advances the sales enablement research by demonstrating how digital technologies facilitate sales enablement initiatives to efficiently and effectively bring dispersed

organizational resources to facilitate high work performance among salespeople. Importantly, the empirically developed digital sales enablement framework is not tied to any specific technologies but rather emphasizes how diverse technological platforms allow a range of essential functionalities for deploying sales enablement.

Third, our study contributes also with new insights about the potential outcomes of sales enablement and also the organizational and infrastructural contingency factors that are required for performance relationships in B2B markets (see MacInnis, 2011). Although existing studies have widely agreed that sales enablement positively impacts salespeople's performance (Westbrook & Peterson, 2020), in reality, organizations' investments in digital technologies often do not produce the desired results (Economic Times, 2023; Guenzi & Habel, 2020). Our study adds important new knowledge to this topic by offering structured insights of the circumstances that are likely to impact the effectiveness of digital sales enablement related to organizational and infrastructural factors (Fig. 1). The findings provide actionable insights to sales leaders and managers for maximizing the benefits of sales enablement deployment.

5.2. Managerial implications

The B2B sales enablement market has seen major developments in the last few years in terms of both its rising strategic importance and the broadening of its scope. Given that sales enablement is an emerging area, and the extant studies have focused on a specific functionality, sales leaders do not have a big picture understanding of sales enablement and are thus forced to undertake implementation incrementally and learn from their experiences (Guenzi & Habel, 2020). That explains challenges faced by organizations to extract significant value from their sales enablement deployment. Our study provides managers with a holistic understanding of sales enablement that covers every sub-activity and component of selling across multiple sales phases. Not long ago, sales enablement primarily focused on providing sellers with relevant, interesting content, but our study highlights that it can also help salespeople gain analytical insights, receive timely coaching, learn and engage in on-boarding, and improve their internal process efficiency and collaboration.

Our study helps managers comprehend the contextual factors that impact the performance of technology-centric sales enablement, which leads to better performance. By focusing on organizational and infrastructural contextual factors, sales leaders can learn what they should do differently to extract value from sales enablement. The study also links sales enablement with overall sales transformation. Since B2B organizations are at different stages of digital sales transformation, this study reminds them to include the strategic objective of developing and sustaining an effective sales enablement platform in their overall transformation strategy.

Last, sales leaders are trying to achieve their revenue and profitability objectives in a workplace plagued by high employee turnover, reduced employment durations, stressed salesforce and demanding customers. Our study provides practical guidance for the application of technology-enabled sales enablement solutions to ensure quick, effective on-boarding. The study recommends that instead of providing general-purpose training with longer duration, organizations would be better off providing on-demand, role- and situation-specific micro-training and coaching tailored to the challenges salespeople are facing. The sales enablement deployment reduces the stress and operational workload on sellers, while providing tangible benefit to the organizations by reducing turnover intention of the salespersons and improving sales performance (Westbrook & Peterson, 2020).

5.3. Limitations and future research

Our study has also some limitations, some of which offer avenues for future research. First, our qualitative study is exploratory in nature and is based solely on interview data from the IS industry. Future research should test the generalizability and robustness of the findings outlined in the digital sales enablement framework (Fig. 1) using data from multiple industries and quantitative methods. For instance, future research can focus on how marketing led initiatives for digital lead generation using inbound techniques (use of websites, social media, blogs, webinars, etc.) and outbound techniques (email campaigns, marketing automation, etc.) can lead to increased sales and organizational performance. Similarly quantitative research examining how sales enablement insights and content affect salespeople customer interactions and whether it has an impact on sales cycle times and sales performance. Furthermore, recent work on customer success management also highlights the importance of communicating the value delivered to customers by post sale as being vital to generate future business (Hochstein et al., 2023). Here new research can focus on the role of sales enablement can facilitate customer success by helping salespeople to better manage the relationships with their customers. The same applies to the other digital sales enablement functions related to internal work efficiency and capability enhancement as well as the proposed contingencies (see Fig. 1).

Second, since our study is cross-sectional in nature, it provides only limited insights into the longitudinal aspects of sales enablement deployment. Recent work by Bonetti et al. (2023) in a retail setting suggests that the impact of the roll out of digital technology related applications like AI calls for a more longitudinal, multimethod research designs to truly understand the transformative impact of these technologies on the organization. This is in keeping with recent work by Agnihotri et al. (2023) and Goel et al. (2024) which suggest that sales research focusing on the impact of digital technologies on the sales function need to be more holistic in nature rather than taking a simplistic approach to the same. Clearly future research would benefit of studying digital sales enablement from longitudinal perspective. For instance, our framework suggests the importance of onboarding and coaching of salespeople. We suggest that future research should look into how sales organizations measure the impact of their digital sales enablement initiatives longitudinally, especially by focusing on how salesperson performance improves as they get exposed to onboarding, coaching and knowledge and skill acquisition using digital means. Similarly, longitudinal research could provide more insights into the processual issues of sales enablement for understanding the requirements for its successful deployment.

Third, our focus is solely on the sales organization's perspective, and therefore, it does not provide any insights into the customer's perspective on digital sales enablement. Understanding how sales enablement initiatives can actually help enable customers to make the right choices, consequently impacting relationship outcomes including firm performance could be the focus of previous research. This is in keeping with emerging academic literature on customer education in B2B contexts (Florea et al., 2022) as well as practitioner's focus on using sales enablement initiatives to enable their customers' resulting in long-term revenue enablement (Ganesh, 2024). Future research can focus on the role of inter-functional coordination between marketing, sales, customer success and how this has an impact on customer related outcomes. For example, research should empirically validate how coordinated efforts across different customer facing teams can help salespeople better manage customer relationships. In a similar vein, studies could examine how the use of internal social media- tools like Slack, Teams, as well as sales enablement platform tools like Digital Sales Rooms and can be used to engage customers to the benefit of both parties.

Fourth, our qualitative study focused on the positive aspects of sales enablement and thereby our results do not provide insights about the potential dark side of sales enablement. Thus, future research should also consider the non-linear relationships and unexpected dark outcomes of enablement for considering its effective long-term deployment. For example, Lauzi et al. (2023) suggest that the deployment of sales enablement initiatives within a company led to organization wide

structural changes. These organization-wide structural changes can lead to new functions being created in the sales organization, adding to increased complexity and ambiguity in the sales process. This complexity may result in interdepartmental/inter-functional conflict and negative effects to firm performance.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Sandip Mukhopadhyay: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Harri Terho:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Rakesh Singh:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Conceptualization. **Deva Rangarajan:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Conceptualization.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.indmarman.2024.12.009.

Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

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